Knowledge at Risk

Censorship challenges, outcomes, and patterns across media

Cases dataset

Who challenges materials and what happens afterward

Titles dataset

How censorship reasons differ across books and other media

Combined conclusion

A more transparent way to connect challenges with affected works

Censorship from challenge to consequence

A challenge begins with an objection

The record identifies an initiator and one or more reasons.

An institution makes a decision

The material may remain available, move, face restrictions, or leave the collection.

The effect reaches individual works

Titles data shows what was targeted and whether patterns change across media.

Main question

How do censorship challenges begin, what consequences do they produce, and how do the reasons differ across media?

“A challenge is an attempt to remove or restrict materials, based upon the objections of a person or group.”
American Library Association

Two datasets answer different parts of the question

Cases

5,369 usable reported case records

Initiator

Recorded reasons

State and location

Documented title outcomes

Titles

84 balanced visualization records

Title and creator

Type of material

Standardized reason groups

Verified source and media identifiers

Sources: Cases-AZSU_2026.xlsx and Censorship Visualization Only Dataset.xlsx.

Our story: what makes a challenge end in removal?

The problem

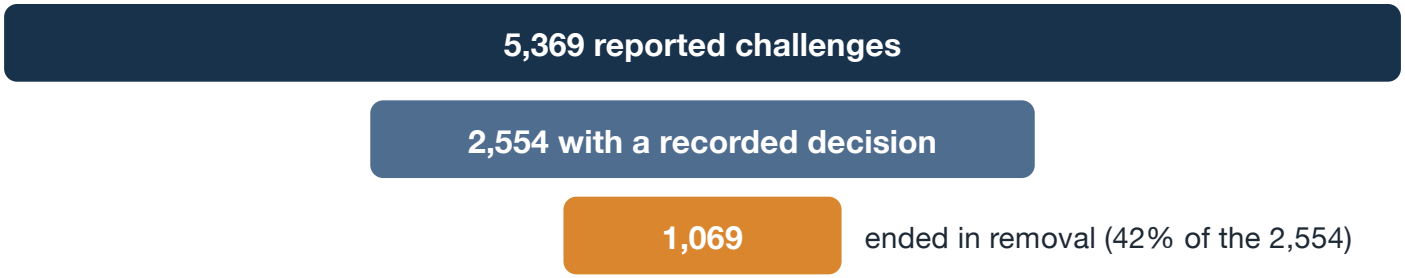
People ask libraries and schools to remove books. Some get pulled, others stay. Why the difference?

The data

5,369 reported challenges, 2016 to 2025. 2,554 record a final decision.

How we looked

I analysed the data, then used predictive modelling to find which factors signal removal.



Our question

When a book is challenged, what decides whether it is removed?

In this section, “removed” means the library or school took at least one challenged book off its shelves.

What the Cases data shows

Plain counts from the Cases data. No model yet.

Initiator



62%

of challenges are filed by parents (31%) or library patrons (30%)

Parents and patrons are the two biggest groups. Based on 5,254 records.

Reasons



39%

cite sexually explicit content, and another 39% cite LGBTQIA+ representation

Reasons overlap, so they don’t add up to 100%.

Withdrawn/Removed



42%

of challenges ended in removal, counting each challenge once

Counted by books, 69% were removed. A few very large challenges push that up. Based on 2,554 cases with a recorded decision.

Source: Cases-AZSU_2026.xlsx.

How I found the factors: predictive modelling

Predictive modelling on the 2,554 cases with a recorded decision

Columns given to the models

Location · State · Year · Initiator · Reasons · Type-format · Count Titles Challenged

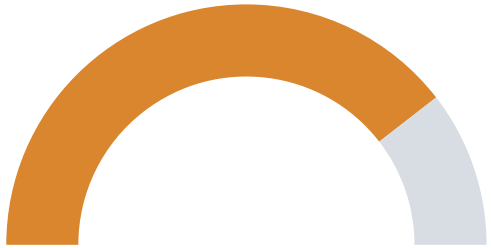
Predictive modelling
learns patterns from past cases

Its prediction
removed or not removed

Did it work? We tested it on cases it had never seen.

79%

of cases were sorted correctly as removed or not removed



about 8 out of 10

Source: Cases-AZSU_2026.xlsx.

Which factors are strong signals of removal

How much accuracy the predictions lose when a column is taken away. Examples are real removal rates in the data.

Strong signal

Location

School Library 68% vs Public Library 13%

Smaller signal

Initiator

Government 97% vs Patron 8%

State

Iowa 84% vs Connecticut 9%

Year

2021 68% vs 2024 32%, no steady trend

Little or no extra

Reasons

Sexually explicit 56% vs unsafe content 19%

Type-format

Film 13% vs Book 43%

Count Titles Challenged

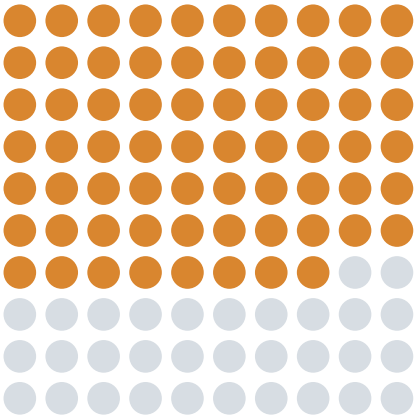
62% for several titles vs 33% for one

Reasons predict a little on their own, but add nothing once Location, State and Initiator are known.

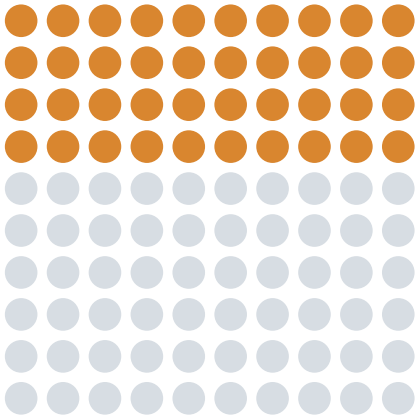
Source: Cases-AZSU_2026.xlsx.

The strongest signal: Location

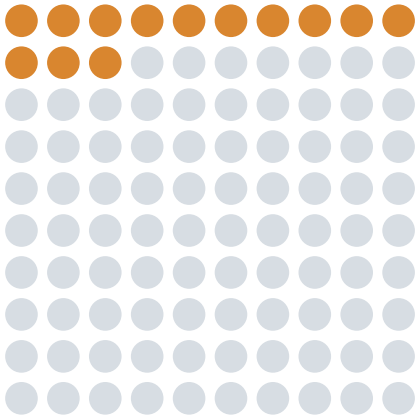
Out of every 100 challenges, how many ended in removal (cases with a known outcome, n = 2,554)



68% **School library**
1,193 challenges



40% **School**
309 challenges



13% **Public library**
1,052 challenges

Same Initiator, different Location: parents' challenges ended in removal 7% of the time in public libraries and 57% in school libraries.

● ended in removal ○ other outcome (retained, restricted, relocated)

Source: Cases-AZSU_2026.xlsx.

Limitations: what to keep in mind

What these results can and cannot tell us

Half the cases have no recorded decision

Only 2,554 of 5,369 records say what happened, so results describe those.

Signals, not causes

The models find patterns that help predict removal. They cannot prove why a book was removed.

Big challenges skew title counts

132 very large challenges hold most removed titles, so I count each challenge once.

Reported challenges only

Many challenges are never reported, so this is not every challenge in the country.

Source: Cases-AZSU_2026.xlsx, 2016–2025.

Equal samples prevent books from dominating the comparison

Version 1 problem

The source data contains far more books than film or music records. Raw counts would mostly reflect dataset size.

Current comparison

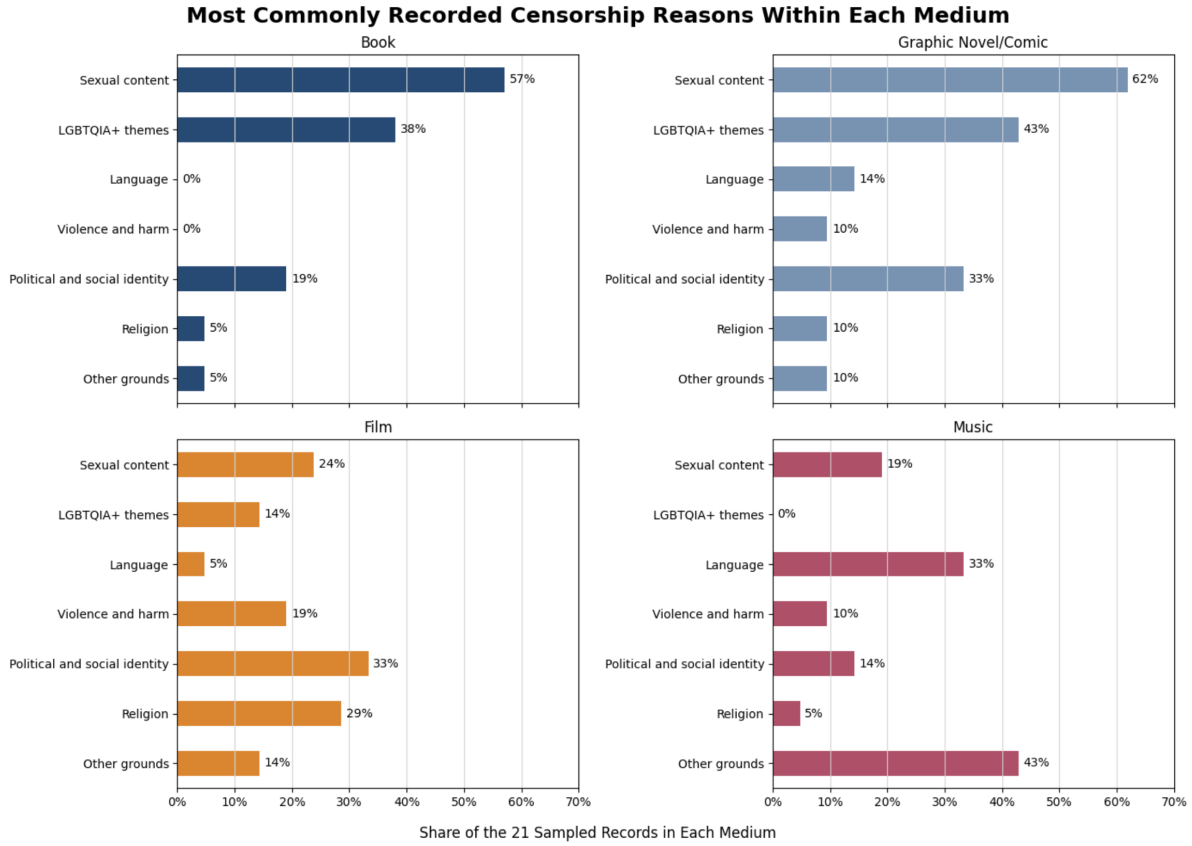
The analysis uses 21 records from each medium and compares shares within those equal groups.

84	21	4	7
records	per medium	media	shared reason groups

This supports a fair descriptive comparison of the sample. It does not estimate censorship rates for the full population.

Jake | 0:50

The leading censorship reasons differ by medium



Books and comics

Sexual content and LGBTQIA+ themes lead both samples.

Film

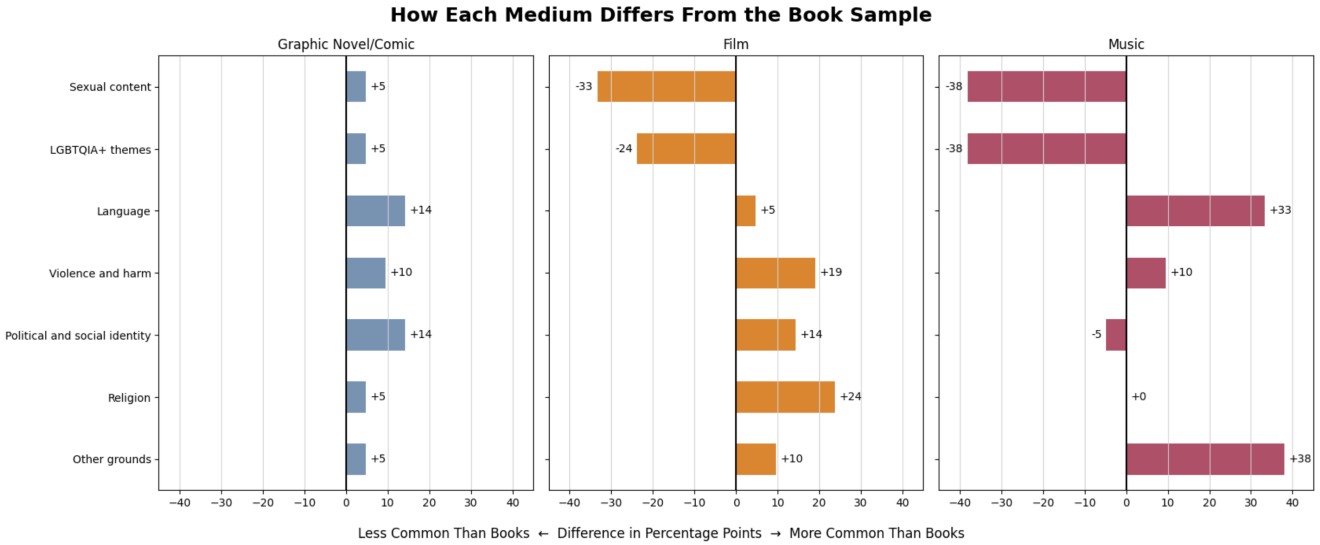
Political or social identity and religion appear more often.

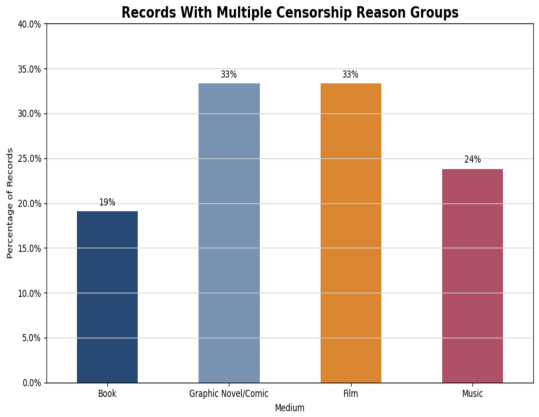
Music

Other grounds and language lead this sample.

Source: balanced Titles visualization sample. Reasons can overlap within one record.

Film and music depart most clearly from the book baseline





Largest differences from books

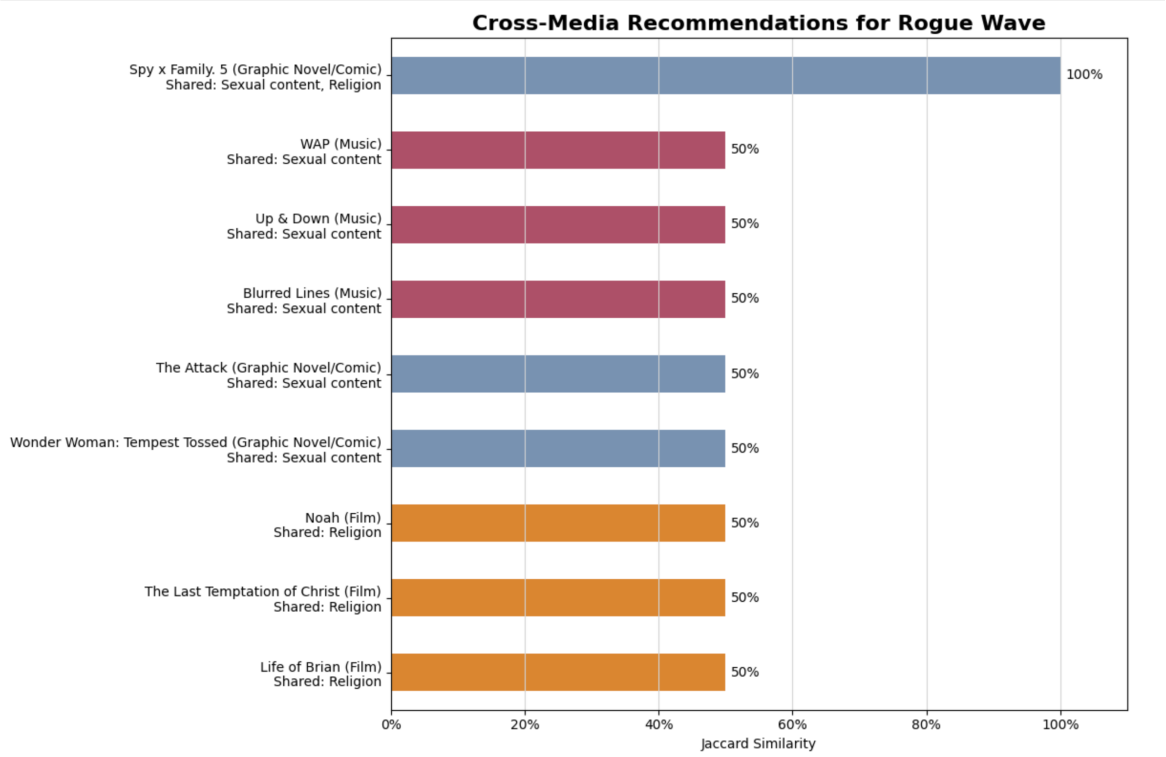
Film: religion +24 points and violence or harm +19

Music: other grounds +38 points and language +33

Multiple reason groups

Comics and Film reach 33%, compared with 19% for Books.

One evidence system can connect challenges with affected works



Combined finding

The Cases data shows that removal depends most on Location: 68% of School Library cases ended in removal, against 13% of Public Library cases. The Titles data shows that the recorded reasons vary across media.

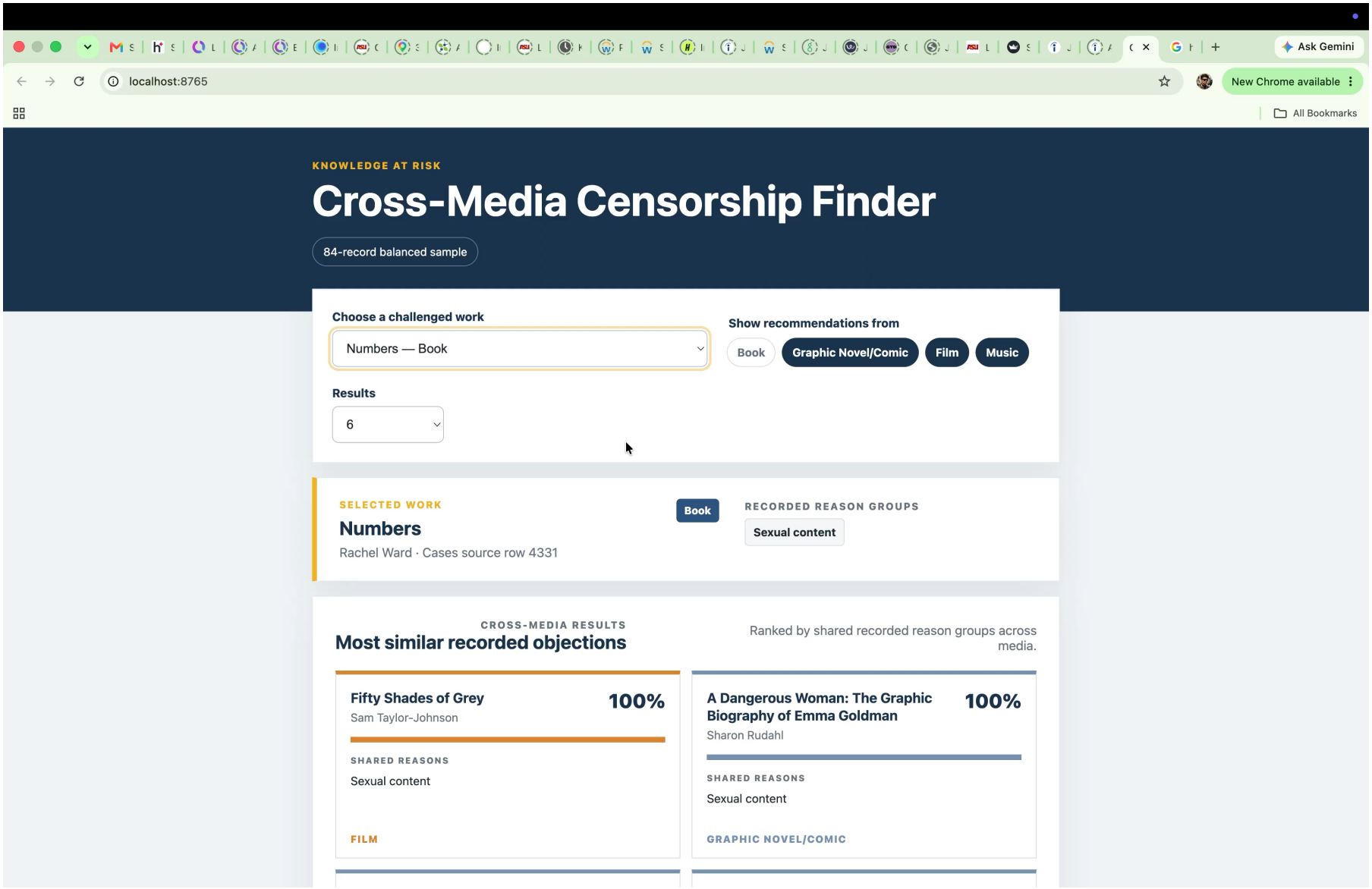
Proposed contribution

A standardized database can connect each challenge, reason, outcome, title, source, and media identifier. The similarity finder demonstrates one way researchers could explore related records.

Limitations

Reported cases do not capture every challenge. Source detail varies. The 84-record cross-media sample is descriptive, not a population estimate.

Similarity compares shared recorded reason groups. It does not measure artistic or thematic similarity.


Ask Gemini
localhost:8765
New Chrome available
All Bookmarks
KNOWLEDGE AT RISK
Cross-Media Censorship Finder
84-record balanced sample
Choose a challenged work
Numbers — Book
Show recommendations from
Book
Graphic Novel/Comic
Film
Music
Results
6
SELECTED WORK
Numbers
Rachel Ward · Cases source row 4331
Book
RECORDED REASON GROUPS
Sexual content
CROSS-MEDIA RESULTS
Most similar recorded objections
Ranked by shared recorded reason groups across media.
Fifty Shades of Grey
Sam Taylor-Johnson
100%
SHARED REASONS
Sexual content
FILM
A Dangerous Woman: The Graphic Biography of Emma Goldman
Sharon Rudahl
100%
SHARED REASONS
Sexual content
GRAPHIC NOVEL/COMIC

References

Definitions and context

American Library Association. About Banned & Challenged Books. ala.org/bbooks/aboutbannedbooks

PEN America. What Is a Book Ban? pen.org/book-bans/book-bans-frequently-asked-questions/

Project data

Cases-AZSU_2026.xlsx. Course-provided Cases dataset.

Censorship_Visualization_Only_Dataset.xlsx. Balanced 84-record Titles sample.

Metadata and method

Spotify for Developers. Web API: Get Track. developer.spotify.com/documentation/web-api/reference/get-track

IMDb Developer. IMDb metadata documentation. developer.imdb.com

scikit-learn. pairwise_distances documentation. scikit-learn.org/stable/modules/generated/sklearn.metrics.pairwise_distances.html

Web sources accessed October 2, 2026. Full record-level provenance remains in the project datasets.